

If you have chosen to synchronize ProtectDrive and the local Windows user database, you authenticate with the same Windows passwords and usernames. The final step in the installation is when you will be prompted to encrypt your hard drive. Choose to reboot and encrypt the drives later.

Booting up: ProtectDrive provides a pre-boot authentication sequence to prevent unauthorized users from booting up your computer. After the BIOS detects the hardware, you need to authenticate to let the computer boot-up. ProtectDrive accepts three incorrect login attempts, after which the computer reboots and the login screen is displayed after a one-minute delay. Enter the correct username and password (usernames are case-specific) to start the Windows boot process. If you have synchronised the Windows accounts with ProtectDrive, you don't need to log on to Windows.

Unlike SafeBoot Solo, you don't have any additional options while booting up.

Usage: After logging on to your account, ProtectDrive informs you of all successful and unsuccessful login attempts. If you run Windows XP, you can

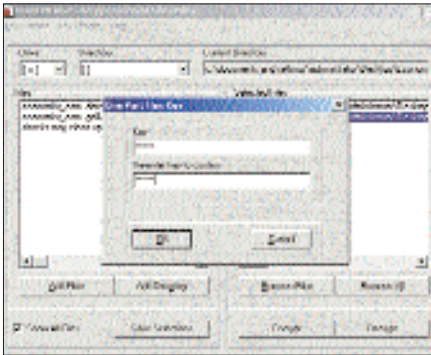
TIP IDEA is an algorithm that has been crypt-analysed for several years now without showing any apparent weaknesses



Encrypting your drives is as easy as choosing the drive, the algorithm, the priority and starting the encryption

lock your computer by double-clicking on the ProtectDrive icon in the system tray. If you have shared folders, ProtectDrive will not permit access unless a valid username is used; guest accounts also have to be password protected.

Encrypting hard drives: Go to **Start > Programs > ProtectDrive** and select Encrypt-Decrypt Hard Drives. Select the drives you would like to encrypt from the list displayed



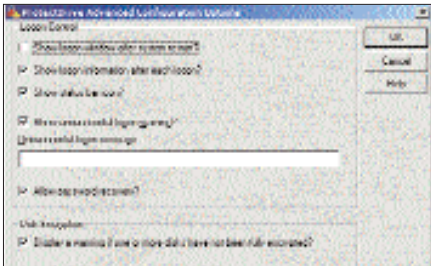
Set pass phrases and secure those files and make sure no one can read them

played on top. You can choose to either encrypt the whole drive, or just the system areas. For optimal security, choose full drive encryption. Depending on the encryption option, you can choose to encrypt the drive volumes using either 56, 64 or 128-bit security.

The encryption priority can be set to low, normal, or high. Selecting low will allow you to continue working through the encryption process. Depending on how powerful your computer is, encryption could take a while.

Encrypting Files: You can use ProtectDrive to encrypt individual files. To do so, go to **Start > Programs > ProtectDrive** and select Encrypt-Decrypt Files. In the left pane, choose the files that you want encrypted and click on Add Files. Select Add Directory to add all the files in a directory. Now choose the files from the right pane and select Encrypt to open the encryption menu. Depending on the settings (key format) that you have selected, you will be prompted to enter the keys. The encryption tool uses the encryption algorithm that you have specified during installation. If you would like to tweak the available options, go to Key Format and choose the

TIP DES is not considered secure anymore by the US government for military grade encryption



Change logon options, set warnings right from the Advanced Configuration Options applet

Track those Crooks

Perhaps of more interest to laptop users is the recent foray of companies such as Phoenix towards developing technologies that deter unauthorised access. Phoenix, for example, is developing an interesting add-on to the BIOS software that they have been developing for decades. The newly developed Core Managed Environment TrustedCore NB for laptops and tablet PCs boasts of cryptographic capabilities built right into the BIOS. This can be used to authenticate digital signatures and restricting access to stolen hardware. It will also protect core system software from malicious code.

Phoenix had earlier partnered with Softex to develop a tracking system which installed on the Core Management Environment. The software connects to the TheftGuard site once a laptop is connected to the Internet, thus making it easy to track it down.

format of the key and Key Length. Decrypting files is just as easy, and is done using the same method, except that you are prompted for your password and need to click on Decrypt instead.

Advanced Configuration: ProtectDrive has several advanced configuration options built into it. You can access and change these, provided you are logged on as the ProtectDrive administrator. Go to **Start > Programs > ProtectDrive** and select Advanced Configuration. You can also choose to show additional logon information, change the way you log on, remove the status bar icon, etc.

Security first

The security tools we used here may not be infallible, but they do offer good security against all, but the most determined crooks. They are not easy to circumvent; certainly, cutting through a length of toughened steel cable, whilst being deafened by a 110 decibel alarm siren is not easy. Nor is it easy for the average crook to crypt-analyse encrypted data and without access to some pretty substantial computing resources.

With the right equipment and careful practices, you can keep your data and laptop safe, and with you always.

SRINIVASAN RAMAKRISHNAN
srinivasan_ramakrishnan@thinkdigit.com